down. We know very well that Marxists and revisionists have differed on the question of power since time immemorial.

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Faced with the uncertain situation across the border, Ulbricht and Honecker tried to counter with the modest means at their disposal. Firstly, they prohibited the sale of Czech newspapers and magazines, stopped issuing exit visas for East German tourists seeking to visit Czechoslovakia and reduced bilateral scientific and cultural exchanges. Soon after, the GDR largely sealed off its border with Czechoslovakia.

Meanwhile, with Dubček stubbornly refusing to pare back reforms, Soviet plans to oust him with military action began to take concrete shape. On 31 July, Ulbricht (with Honecker), along with several other Eastern bloc leaders, arrived at the Kremlin to hear Brezhnev lay out exactly how the Prague situation would unfold. However, before the bayonet was thrust, the unlikely negotiating team of Ulbricht and Honecker were dispatched to Karlovy Vary in Czechoslovakia for one last attempt at twisting Dubček's arm. Rather worryingly, after seven hours of coaxing and cajoling, their attempts to talk the Czech into going slow on reforms failed, prompting a Western reporter to cynically remark, 'Ulbricht senses in the Czechoslovak reform programme the death knell of his own brand of regime.'2

Patience exhausted, Brezhnev gave the green light to the joint invasion of Czechoslovakia by soldiers from four Warsaw Pact countries – USSR, Poland, Bulgaria and Hungary – on the night of 20-21 August 1968. For all the historic significance of this moment, not a single NVA troop marched over the border, given the sensitivities of Hitler's invasion thirty years earlier. The Germans, according to Brezhnev, 'were bitter about their exclusion from the invasion force'.3 Relegated to spectator status, Ulbricht and Honecker could only listen to the largest deployment of military force in Europe since the Second World War over secret shortwave military communications. Honecker's beloved NVA was limited to providing intelligence and logistical support, which, in reality, meant securing the